

DRUG-PREP

SUMMARY REPORT ON COUNTRY-SPECIFIC INSIGHTS BASED ON HORIZON SCANNING



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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This report compiles the methodology and results of horizon scanning exercises carried out across the six countries involved in the DRUG-PREP project: Belgium, Czechia, Finland, Ireland, the Netherlands, and Portugal. Horizon scanning is a participatory process that aims to collect signals about current or imminent changes (events or trends) that are potential indications of new emerging issues (European Foresight Platform, n.d.-a). Within DRUG-PREP, the aim of horizon scanning was to identify and validate the trends and megatrends that may affect the future of drugs in each country until 2030+.

A general research methodology for horizon scanning was used, covering three steps: (1) Identifying trends and megatrends through literature review; (2) Describing and understanding the trends and their implications; (3) Validating and prioritising the trends through workshops with national experts. A broad perspective was taken, covering societal, technological, environmental, economic and political aspects (following the STEEP framework) to avoid blind spots. This was the first time carrying out such an exercise in the drugs field in most of the involved countries, and provided important learnings for future iterations. Despite a shared methodological guideline, there were some differences in the frameworks applied and the implementation. These differences and some lessons learnt from them are outlined in this report.

The results section includes a list of all the trends and megatrends identified in the six countries, across all STEEP areas. The identified trends and their implications differ quite widely. Of 59 trends identified across the countries, eight were identified by more than one country. Most of the cross-cutting trends (i.e., identified by more than one country) are megatrends in line with the JRC megatrends hub (JRC, n.d.). Some countries focused solely on wider trends (outside the drugs sphere) while others also included drug-specific trends. The country-specific insights for the cross-cutting trends (those identified by more than one country) are included in this report. A separate Annex document includes the detailed results per country. The added value of performing foresight exercises on drugs at the national level can be seen in the different implications that were identified at the national level, demonstrating national specificities. Given the variety in approach used and trends identified, it is difficult to perform a detailed comparative analysis of the findings and implications across countries. Additionally, as the aim of DRUG-PREP was to carry out parallel national-level activities, this was not the objective of the project.

DRUG-PREP was also valuable in providing capacity building opportunities for foresight in several countries, as well as demonstrating the added value of participatory approaches to achieve a joint vision of the future between national stakeholders. Foresight can help to address developments in drug markets, prevalence of substance use, and evolving challenges in drug policy, among others, contributing significantly to the field's advancement. A regular repetition of horizon scanning exercises can help national drug monitoring centres to adapt their activities in line with changes in long-term outlooks (EMCDDA, 2023).

INTRODUCTION

Recent years have seen an increased focus on future-oriented approaches in the EU policy sphere. Growing challenges such as climate change, political instability and rapid technological change mean that the future is complex and uncertain, and requires proactively anticipating challenges rather than depending on a reactive response. Foresight can be described as “a systematic participatory process, creating collective intelligence about the medium to long-term future. It is aimed at informing present day decisions and mobilising joint actions, key features to support policy making” (Galvin, 2023).

While foresight has been widely used in other sectors, its implementation in the drugs field has previously remained relatively limited. However, the EU Drugs Strategy 2021-2025 notes the importance of building “foresight capacities necessary to enable a more effective, innovative and agile approach to the growing complexity of the drugs phenomenon, and to increase the preparedness of the EU and its Member States to respond to future challenges and crises” (Council of the European Union, 2021). The European Union Drugs Agency (EUDA, former EMCDDA) carried out a ‘Futures Exercise 2030’ to inform strategic reflection on how to improve its activities in the context of this rapidly changing environment (EMCDDA, 2023). The application of foresight to the drugs sphere is important in recognition of the fast-changing and inter-connected nature of drugs and addiction.

In this context, the DRUG-PREP project aimed to translate this impetus to EU member states, to fill the existing gap in national foresight research in the drugs field. The aim of DRUG-PREP was to better understand current and future trends and developments in countries, and support preparedness of national drug monitoring and response systems. Applying drug-related foresight at the national level in parallel to EU activities is important as national specificities and developments (for example in terms of demographics, economics, governance structures, culture and history) mean that trends and their impacts may differ. Building capacity for futures-based approaches in-country is important to allow better understanding of national developments and their differences, or their convergences, with other countries and the EU level. By facilitating a process of systematic collective reflection among stakeholders, foresight research can support countries in strengthening their preparedness and policy makers in making strategic decisions that are fit for the future.

Between 2022 and 2024, the DRUG-PREP partners carried out individual national foresight exercises in the six countries involved in the project: Belgium, Czechia, Finland, Ireland, the Netherlands, and Portugal. As horizon scanning forms the basis for most foresight projects, each country performed a horizon scanning exercise to identify and validate the trends and megatrends that may affect the future of drugs in the country by

2030+. This time frame was selected to explore medium-term developments and their implications, striking a balance between being long enough to capture emerging trends while short enough to be relevant to current policymakers. Horizon scanning is an approach for collecting trends or signals about current or imminent changes that are potential indications of new emerging issues (European Foresight Platform, n.d.-a). A trend is “a general tendency or direction of a development or change over time. It can be called a megatrend if it occurs at global or large scale. A trend may be strong or weak, increasing, decreasing or stable” (European Foresight Platform, n.d.-b).

This document compiles the methodologies and results of the horizon scanning and trend analysis exercises carried out in each participating country. Although a common research framework was developed, there were slight differences in the methodology used. While this makes a comparative analysis difficult, it demonstrates the versatility of foresight methods and provides valuable lessons learnt on the choices that can be made and pitfalls to avoid. Readers are invited to refer to another document ‘Summary report of recommendations and best practices for national implementation of foresight strategies’ for recommendations based on those lessons learnt (DRUG-PREP consortium, 2025).

METHODOLOGY

Each country carried out horizon scanning based on a methodological toolkit developed in the project (DRUG-PREP consortium, 2023). A broad perspective was taken following the STEEP framework, covering Societal, Technological, Environmental, Economic and Political aspects to help avoid blind spots.

The methodology was based on the following overarching steps:



Trend identification: literature review to identify trends and megatrends that could impact the future of drugs in each country



Turning it into future intelligence: describing and understanding trends and their implications



Expert validation: workshops with national experts to validate the identified trends and consider potential impacts

The table below provides an overview of some of the main methodological differences observed between the countries in applying this methodology. The next paragraphs explain each step, the differences observed, and some learnings from those differences.

MAIN METHODOLOGICAL DIFFERENCES

						
	Belgium	Czechia	Finland	Ireland	Netherlands	Portugal
Trend identification		Included drug-specific trends	✓	✓	✓	
		Focused on all STEEP areas	✓	✓	✓	
	✓	Used scientific literature	✓	✓	✓	
	✓	Used grey literature (e.g., national reports, evaluations, foresight reports)	✓	✓	✓	✓
Expert validation	✓	Invited external stakeholders	✓	✓		✓
	✓	Invited policymakers		✓		✓



TREND IDENTIFICATION

Literature review to identify trends and megatrends that could impact the future of drugs in each country

A literature review for trend identification involves the following four steps:

1. Define the topic and scope of your trend research
2. Define guiding questions for systematic scanning
3. Define selection criteria for studies to include
4. Perform trend scanning

1 Define the topic and scope of your trend research

Before beginning a foresight research project, it is important to define its scope thematically, geographically and by time horizon (DRUG-PREP consortium, 2023). In terms of geographical scope and time horizon, the same approach was adopted across all countries. The geographical scope was the national level, and the time horizon was 2030+, to explore medium-term trends and implications while retaining relevance to current policymakers. The thematic scope was the illicit drugs phenomenon, covering the topic from a wide angle including drug use, drug production and supply, harm reduction and healthcare services, among others.

2 Define guiding questions a systematic scanning

Questions to guide systematic scanning of the literature for trend identification included: What is shaping the future of drugs in (country) until 2030? What changes can we observe? How could they develop in the future? Further questions could be posed, for instance to explore drug-specific trends, such as: Is societal tolerance to drug consumption changing? How is the production of drugs developing? Are there changes in policies and regulations regarding drug consumption or control?

The DRUG-PREP methodology employed an ‘outside-in’ perspective in the first instance, starting from the wider environment and considering how wider trends could alter the drugs field (e.g., how economic developments could impact on consumption habits, drug production, provision of services). The STEEP framework helps to ensure that the issue is addressed in a 360° approach, avoiding blind spots. An alternative perspective is to directly identify trends within the field of drugs (e.g., changes in consumption of certain drug types, changes in demographics of people who use drugs, changes in drug legislation) and consider how these can interplay or impact each other. There are benefits and pitfalls to both approaches: focusing too much on trends within the drugs field risks a siloed approach and may lead to futures based on the status quo without looking outside

the field of expertise of the researchers. Focusing too much on the wider perspective without taking into account drug-specific trends risks ignoring valuable knowledge.

Some countries did not include trends across all STEEP fields, opting to focus on specific fields. This was mainly due to time and resource constraints limiting a wider analysis, as well as the area of expertise of the researchers involved. Portugal focused on society, environment and technology, while Belgium focused on all fields except for economics. The importance of a 360° approach in horizon scanning must be underlined: omitting certain fields can miss important trends and limit the value of the exercise.

3 Define selection criteria for studies to include

To guide the selection of literature from which trends can be identified, it is important to define clear inclusion criteria. The guidance for inclusion criteria provided in the DRUG-PREP toolkit (DRUG-PREP consortium, 2023) was:

- Primary scientific literature and derivative products (with emphasis on national publications with a trend or foresight-based approach)
- EU and/or country specific
- Published in the last seven years
- Sources with demonstrable validity and credibility

Most of these inclusion criteria were broadly followed by the participating countries. The types of sources used for the literature review varied more widely, with some countries focusing on grey literature while others employed a scientific literature search. Both approaches come with strengths and limitations. Scientific literature reviews provide rigour, transparency and reproducibility, and ensure that the identified trends are evidence-based. However, this method may miss emerging trends or issues that have not been studied in academic outlets, translating existing biases into the horizon scanning results. Conversely, non-systematic searches relying on grey literature may reduce the scientific robustness and comparability of the findings. Integrating knowledge from previous high-quality foresight exercises is important, to build on existing knowledge. Ideally, a combined approach should be adopted that combines scientific literature, grey literature and existing foresight studies.

4 Perform trend scanning

Trends are identified in the literature when documents indicate a direction of change over time. This leads to a long list of trends, which are clustered by combining related findings. The guiding questions for identifying trends were: What are national developments and potential disruptors influencing the future of drugs in our country until 2030+? Which EU-wide or global trends are especially relevant for our national context? A template was provided to support the researchers in identifying trends. Researchers were encouraged to cover trends from all STEEP fields and aim for a set of 8-12 trends in total. When attributing trends to a STEEP category, the attribution is based on the field which the trend originates from, as opposed to where the impacts are felt. Overall, countries used similar approaches for trend identification based on the literature in each country.



TURNING IT INTO FUTURE INTELLIGENCE

Describing and understanding trends and their implications

The next step is to understand how each trend has developed so far and what effects it could have on the drugs field. The trends identified are described, including the evidence and insights about recent and past developments, possible or expected future developments, and impacts on the drugs field. Further research that might be required to find out more specific insights on the topic can also be described (DRUG-PREP consortium, 2023). The format of the trend descriptions varied between different countries, but most developed ‘trend cards’, including a short description of the trend and its potential impacts.



EXPERT VALIDATION

Running a trends workshop

After identifying and describing trends that may affect the future of drugs in their country, the project partners organised expert workshops to validate the identified trends and further explore their potential implications. The EMCDDA toolkit for organising a trend impact workshop was often used to guide the workshop organisation (EMCDDA, 2022). Most workshops took place over 2-3 hours, in person.

Most of the countries included a variety of disciplines/perspectives in the workshops, to achieve a nuanced understanding of the implication of identified trends. However, participants varied slightly, for instance in terms of whether stakeholders outside the organisation were invited, and specifically whether policymakers were included.

The workshop in the Netherlands included only experts from within the organisation that was involved in DRUG-PREP, as the workshop aimed to build foresight capacity within the institute before integrating external stakeholders. The other countries in the consortium involved external participants in their workshops. Different options for expert involvement are valid as long as these are aligned with the project’s objectives.

In Finland, high-level policymakers were not included in the workshop to avoid potential bias. The researchers noted that policymakers’ perspectives are often shaped by policy-driven and macro-level considerations that may not fully reflect the on-the-ground realities faced by individuals who use drugs and those providing support services (Unlu et al., 2024). Other countries in the consortium (e.g., Belgium, Ireland) did include policymakers based on the fact that as the knowledge user, the policy experts will be most interested in the outcomes of the foresight exercise, and their involvement in the exercise increases the chances of the findings influencing the policy process. The inclusion of different types of stakeholders who may have opposing views on certain issues allows for very valuable discussions. There is no right or wrong answer to the involvement of policymakers in the workshops, as long as the implications of each decision are recognised by the researchers and the decision aligns with the project’s objectives.

RESULTS

IDENTIFIED TRENDS

The tables below include the full list of trends identified across the countries, organised according to the STEEP categories. Some countries also identified drug-specific trends within the STEEP fields. Most of the countries identified both trends specific to their country, as well as megatrends. Megatrends are long-term developments that affect the global level, although they may have regional differences (EMCDDA, 2023). The trends are presented from megatrends down to drug-specific trends. Megatrends identified by several countries are noted in green font, drug-specific trends are in red font, and black font indicates trends that are neither megatrends nor drug-specific trends.

POLITICAL TRENDS



Belgium



Czechia



Finland



Ireland



Netherlands



Portugal

MEGA TREND	New governing systems	✓			✓	
	Changing security paradigm			✓		
	Belgian political structure: focus on cities; decentralisation	✓				
	Changes in legislation and policy		✓			
	Populism ideology		✓			
	War in Ukraine influence all levels of society		✓			
	New landscape of decision-making			✓		
	New shape of public service			✓		
	Political ignorance and governmental failures				✓	
DRUG-SPECIFIC	Shift in discourse of addiction (decriminalisation) / Normalisation of drug use		✓			
	Changes in drug policy and regulation		✓	✓		

ENVIRONMENTAL TRENDS



Belgium



Czechia



Finland



Ireland



Netherlands



Portugal

MEGA TREND	Climate change and environmental degradation	✓	✓		✓	✓
	Resource scarcity			✓		✓
	Increasing energy consumption		✓			
	Environmental awareness					✓
	Climate crisis					✓
	Impact of drugs on ecosystem			✓		

SOCIETAL TRENDS							
		Belgium	Czechia	Finland	Ireland	Netherlands	Portugal
MEGA TREND	Diversifying inequalities	✓	✓		✓		✓
	Shifting health challenges	✓	✓		✓	✓	
	Urbanisation				✓		
	Diversification of education and learning				✓		
	Increasing demographic imbalances				✓		
	Deteriorating mental health		✓				
	Population change	✓	✓			✓	✓
	Changing nature of work				✓		
	Education inequalities				✓		
	Family breakdown				✓		
	Social fragmentation and discontent among citizens					✓	
	Increased levels of education and health						✓
	Touristification						✓
	Hyperindividualism						✓
DRUG-SPECIFIC	Use of psychoactive drugs, polyvalent use		✓				
	Increasing risks in new subgroups of people who use drugs			✓			
	Drug-related mortality			✓			
	Increasing use of synthetic drugs, prescription drugs and polydrug use			✓			
	Changing social values			✓			
	Changes in organised crime				✓		
	Patterns in drug use: increase in micro dosing, medication use without prescription, cannabis use, human enhancement drugs					✓	
	Profiles of people who use drugs: elderly using drugs					✓	
	Societal developments: therapeutic drug use, discussion on legalisation, drug crime that undermines society, violent incidents by drug criminals					✓	

TECHNOLOGICAL TRENDS							
		Belgium	Czechia	Finland	Ireland	Netherlands	Portugal
MEGA TREND	Increased connectivity and digitalisation process / New digital environment	✓	✓	✓			✓
	Accelerating technological change		✓		✓	✓	
	Technological innovations in science	✓					
	Cybercrime				✓		
	Online entertainment				✓		
	Growing digital divide				✓		
DRUG-SPECIFIC	Changes in physical work environment				✓		
	New inventions in treatment and harm reduction			✓			

ECONOMIC TRENDS							
		Belgium	Czechia	Finland	Ireland	Netherlands	Portugal
MEGA TREND	Growing influence of the East and South				✓		
	High labour utilisation rate but low productivity		✓				
	Consequences of a global economy		✓				
	Economic burden of health costs			✓			
	Emphasis on wellbeing				✓		
	Continuing intergenerational inequalities				✓		
DRUG-SPECIFIC	Changing national and global economy					✓	
	Changes in drug market/distribution		✓				
	Availability of substances				✓		
	Drug markets: dealers that share prevention strategies, professionalizing marketing of drugs, mixed markets (legal/illegal)						✓

INSIGHTS ON IMPLICATIONS OF SELECTED TRENDS

This section provides a summary of the country-specific implications of the trends that were identified by several countries.

The trends identified by more than one country, and which are presented here, are:

A. Changes in drug policy and regulation

B. Diversifying and increasing inequalities

C. Shifting health challenges

D. Population change

E. Increased connectivity and digitalisation process

F. Accelerating technological change / technological innovations

G. Climate change and environmental degradation

The implications described below are all based on the inputs of workshop participants in each of the national horizon scanning exercises.

Given the number and diversity of trends identified across the countries, not all of them are described here. A full report for each country's exercise - including all identified trends and their implications - can be found in a separate Annex document.

Changes in drug policy and regulation

About the trend

Shifts in drug policy may be attributed to changing social values or norms, with differing approaches across European countries. For instance, in Finland evolving societal attitudes toward drugs has led to increased calls for policy reforms (Unlu et al., 2024).

Finland

Detailed analysis of the implications of the Finnish exercise are outlined by Unlu et al (Unlu et al., 2024). In brief, current governance by more conservative parties suggests that short-term significant progress is unlikely. Substantial changes could be expected over a 7-8 year period. In Finland, parliamentary deliberations are awaited on two key initiatives: cannabis and drug consumption rooms. There is growing societal support for drug policy reform at the grassroots level.

Czechia

It In Czechia, it was noted that changes in legislation and policy may imply an overburdened care system, criminalisation of users or system instability (due to political changes). Changes in the regulatory framework may lead to reduction of incarcerated people, use, punitive measures, legislation, increase of state budget income, increase of information, prevention. These system changes imply a need for creation of an agency, with an expansion in services available. was noted that climate change may lead to changes in distribution routes and production areas. It is important to monitor and report on changing supply routes (e.g., by the National Focal Point, police).

B Diversifying and increasing inequalities

About the trend

Recent years have seen an increase in inequalities both within countries and at a global scale, with a widening wealth gap and worsening socioeconomic conditions for many. Inequalities can be seen in income disparities, unequal access to education, access to housing, gender inequalities, and employment uncertainty, among others.

Belgium

Workshop participants noted that underprivileged or marginalised groups are most vulnerable to drug related threats, such as the lure for easy financial gain in the drug criminality field. There is a risk of a “vicious cycle” of inequalities: people from underprivileged groups have an increased risk of use of cheap drugs with more health risks, and also have more difficult access to the care needed. In general, there is a need for a more holistic approach to tackle drug use, in recognition of the wider social determinants of drug use. The risk of worsening inequalities was raised across several other trends.

Portugal

In recent years, Portugal has seen an increase in inequalities, as a result of the economic crisis and the COVID-19 pandemic. As a result of the worsening of socioeconomic conditions, there was an increase in the consumption of alcohol, injecting drugs, crack, and synthetic drugs. The pandemic also contributed to more relapses among people who use drugs. The worsening economic situation could lead to more harmful use of illicit drugs. It is important to ensure health care for vulnerable populations. For example, migrants who arrive in the country illegally are not registered in the National Health System, which makes it difficult to access health services. Health care offers differ across regions, and it is important to reduce regional discrepancies. Monitoring should focus on epidemiological surveys and qualitative studies (national or local level). More focus is needed on drug checking, and information from Integrated Response Operational Programs (PORI) network can be better used. It is important to collect information from the National Institute of Medical Emergencies (INEM), and emergency rooms.

Ireland

Ireland’s economic stability has resulted in an increasing proportion of the population who were born in other countries. The increasing demand for resources such as housing and healthcare will entrench existing inequalities and less opportunities for many. In terms of education inequalities, the increasing emphasis on third level education will put pressure on those lacking the resources to pursue several years study. Lack of support for primary and secondary students with learning needs will exacerbate inequalities. Continuing inter-generational inequalities imply that consistency of high levels of deprivation in certain areas is a predictor of fewer opportunities and greater levels of problem substance use.

Czechia

The participants focused on geographical and employment inequalities. It was noted that inequalities mean vulnerable groups are at high risk of social exclusion, not being able to access services, and stigma. Inequalities between urban and rural areas are seen in the expansion of vulnerable groups with impaired access to services. Regarding workplace inequalities, it was noted that there is a need for prioritisation of topics such as subsidy management and distribution of financial resources. This implies a need for editing of strategic documents, increasing awareness and response within subsidy management, and considering the impact on monitoring. The increasing difference between regions and deterioration of the social situation of clients (unemployment) increases demand for services but a lack of capacity. The financial threshold for subsidy management needs to be increased.

C Shifting health challenges

About the trend

People are living longer, and an ageing population brings particular health challenges. The incidence of communicable diseases is decreasing but non-communicable and chronic diseases such as diabetes and cardiovascular disease are increasing. Mental health issues are also increasingly in focus (e.g., depression and anxiety). The capacity of mental health services to respond to the increasing awareness of mental health and emphasis placed on it by younger cohorts in the population will be tested.

Belgium

Participants noted that a rise in mental health issues could lead to an increase in drug consumption, including use of prescribed drugs (e.g., Ritalin use among students). Conversely, there is a trend towards more focus on mental health, which could see improved promotion and prevention. In addition, there is also a potential increase in pro-health behaviours (e.g., indications of a more moderate alcohol consumption or even abstinence). Importantly, underprivileged groups are often more affected. The profile of people who use drugs is ageing, which brings associated health concerns and health challenges. Harm reduction practices are increasing, but participants underlined that a legal framework allowing for harm reduction practices is lacking and urgently needed in Belgium.

Netherlands

Possible implications of shifting health challenges include (increased) drug use caused by poor mental health, as well as among vulnerable populations. Additionally, there could be a normalisation of drug use and increases in work-related drug use.

Ireland

An aging population will have particular health challenges. The capacity of mental health services to respond to the increasing awareness of mental health and emphasis placed on it by younger cohorts in the population will be tested.

Czechia

There is increased focus placed on the link between addictive behaviour and mental health, with new types of services and interventions. However, there may also be changes in patterns of use, such as new drugs and misuse. The implications for the workplace include a need for new types of services adapted to emerging needs.

D Population change

About the trend

The megatrend 'population change' encompasses several processes that are occurring. The demographic make-up of the global (and European) population is changing with increasing demographic imbalances, including a rising elderly population, and increasing migration and urbanisation (EMCDDA, 2023).

Belgium

Participants highlighted that urban areas act as hubs for population change with increasing population density and potential resource struggles. Precariousness, poverty and disconnect in urban areas could lead to increased drug use. New subpopulations with different substance use patterns may emerge. There is a need for services adapted to different populations' needs to avoid aggravating inequalities. The role of the media in framing issues related to migration must be recognised, to promote integration and ensure that people with a migration background have equal access to services. An ageing profile of people who use drugs with associated health concerns need services adapted to their needs. Decision-making must balance conflicting needs of different subpopulations, which may be complex. Population change may affect international criminal networks and mechanisms of criminality, diversifying the reach of drug markets.

Netherlands

Although welfare has increased in the past decades, not everyone has equally benefited from this rise. A significant group (16%) lags behind in life expectancy, health, employment, and income security. COVID-19, inflation, and related societal challenges intensified the issues faced by this vulnerable group. Society is becoming increasingly diverse as the number of people with a migration background continues to grow, and emancipation movements create more room for diversity. The proportion of elderly people in society is growing, posing challenges in healthcare and social participation (van Oudenhoven-van der Zee, 2023). A larger portion of the population consists of highly educated individuals (vander Mooren & de Vries, 2022).

Ireland

Ireland's population is not aging as rapidly as some other European countries, but the ratio of working population to retired will steadily decrease impacting on healthcare costs and other supports.

Czechia

It was noted that an ageing population with worsening mental and physical health may lead to system overloading, impacting on the quality of services provided. This has an impact on monitoring, requiring monitoring of a diversified portfolio of topics.

Portugal

The Portuguese population is ageing, and young people increasingly leave in search of opportunities, particularly in rural areas in the country's interior. The demographic imbalance is mitigated by the arrival of foreigners, including digital nomads, retirees, refugees, migrants and unskilled labour from developing countries. People with a migration background are a vulnerable section of the population regarding addictive behaviours. On the other hand, immigration can make an important contribution to development and to solving the country's demographic issues. Fewer young people may mean a lower prevalence of drug use. New drug patterns may emerge among migrant groups or in specific parts of the country which may attract young people in particular (e.g. Idanha area near Boom Festival). Epidemiological studies aimed at vulnerable migratory populations and qualitative studies on rural areas are needed. NGOs and refugee support services should be integrated into the monitoring system. Political responses aimed at vulnerable migratory populations should be reinforced.

E Increased connectivity and digitalisation process

About the trend

The digitalisation process is rapidly increasing leading to a process of hyperconnectivity. Hyperconnectivity, the ‘internet of things’, augmented reality and collective intelligence systems, combined with falling costs of implementation of new technologies are transforming entire systems of production, management and governance (EMCDDA, 2023).

Belgium

The wide-ranging impact of increasing connectivity and digitalisation was recognised as both an opportunity and a threat. Increased digital literacy may improve knowledge on substances and harm reduction. Access to online care may lower the threshold for services and access to non-state support networks. However, increased connectivity may also increase disinformation about substances. The digital divide negatively impacts vulnerable groups. Digitalisation facilitates online (illegal) markets and micro-transactions, providing easier access to drugs with “the world as a marketplace” and expanding portfolios of dealers who can target consumers through social media. Online sales are particularly difficult to regulate. Finally, digitalisation and connectivity could also increase the prevalence of and emergence of new addictions (e.g., gaming, gambling, social media).

Finland

Detailed analysis of the Finnish insights on digitalisation is available in the Unlu et al (2024). The digitalisation process has a wide impact on the drugs field, from developments of digital platforms to emergence of new drug trends. Finns are better equipped to access international platforms and contribute to dynamic group formation and platform usage. With increased internet engagement, new problems are emerging. Online gaming cultures potentially prone to stimulant use, however gamers remain a small segment of the overall vulnerable population. Online sales facilitate access to drugs, however a decline in drug sales via the Tor network in the past two years suggests a shift to new platforms. Continuous social media monitoring is important for detecting emerging drug trends.

Czechia

The digitalisation process may facilitate the availability and emergence of new types of services. However, it also facilitates online availability of drugs, innovations in drug production and globalisation of the market. It is important to accelerate policy processes (e.g., legislative changes) and coordinate the timing of these.

Portugal

Digitalisation has reformed production and trade processes, and became even more important with the COVID-19 pandemic. There is a focus on teleworking, and discussions on changing working hours, which could lead to a more free time. At the same time, greater connectivity is anticipated, with both advantages and disadvantages. Digitisation could lead to the end of certain jobs and increased unemployment and drug use as coping strategies. Improved working conditions through teleworking could mean fewer people using illicit drugs (especially stimulants) as a response to everyday stress. However, increasing free time may provide more opportunities to use illicit drugs. The digital divide among people with problematic drug use brings a greater difficulty in accessing a job, and social exclusion. Digital literacy of people with problematic drug use should be reinforced. Programs for access to the world of work must be created for this population, considering that today the world of work involves skills in the IT area. Interventions in recreational settings must be strengthened.

F Accelerating technological change / technological innovations

About the trend

Technological innovations are pushing forward new possibilities/applications in different domains such as robotics, artificial intelligence (AI), nanotechnology, quantum computing, etc. There are increasing possibilities in AI and immersive technologies. The role of technology in healthcare is increasing, for instance with the development of new technologies including robotics.

Belgium

Technological innovations in science, including the development of artificial intelligence (AI), could impact many spheres. In terms of drug supply, it could lead to a rapidly evolving drug market of new compounds that are difficult to trace. Technological innovation could lead to new production, trading and transport techniques, and increased drug supply through cheaper (localised) production techniques. Conversely, methods for monitoring, substance analysis and detection may further improve. Pharmaceutical innovations may lead to the development of new medicines as substitutes for drugs. Technological innovation in science could also offer an opportunity through the development of new e-health services (e.g., AI therapist), advanced health technologies in neuroscience and nanotechnology (e.g., brain stimulation), or personalised medicine. Online support or treatment may lower the threshold for access. It is important to consider ethical and social consequences, for instance unequal access to new technologies or unethical use of health data.

Czechia

Social problems may be aggravated due to technological and environmental changes. Technological change may contribute to new addictions, loss of social contact and resulting mental health and drug use problems. The implications include a need for editing of strategic documents, increasing awareness of new topics, as well as considering the impact on monitoring. Innovations and new technologies may lead to increases in new types of services (alcohol, tobacco) but also new drugs, expansion of availability (substitution of methamphetamine and new forms of substitution).

Ireland

Participants highlighted that accelerating technological change will impact on all aspects of society including the workplace, education, criminal activity and the response to it and Ireland's attractiveness to foreign direct investment (FDI).

Netherlands

The use of social media as an information source for drug-related information is increasing. Technological change means that there is rapid development of new drugs, but also increasing use of e-health in drug prevention and addiction care. Additionally, technological advancements allow anonymous and safe drug waste drop-off points, and on the spot drug testing on festivals.



Climate change and environmental degradation

About the trend

Human activity is leading to irreversible and severe changes to the climate through pollution and greenhouse gas emissions, causing global warming, ocean acidification, desertification, changing climate patterns and environmental degradation (EMCDDA, 2023). The effects of climate change differ between global regions, but in Europe it can be seen in increased frequency of heatwaves, heat-related mortality, increased precipitation and risk of floods, decreased water quality and availability, among others. However, climate awareness is also increasing, with a growing sensibility and cultural shifts, as well as climate-focused policies.

Belgium

The impact of climate change on the drugs sector in Belgium may be felt in terms of changing patterns of use due to climate migration. Environmental degradation caused by climate change in areas of production may increase the focus on synthetic drugs – and new psychoactive substances (NPS) in general – with unknown origins and ingredients, possibly inducing a shift from organic drugs towards synthetic drugs. It is important to consider the risk of environmental degradation from toxic waste of synthetic drug production. However, changing norms and values may mean that people who use synthetic drugs consider the environmental impact, which may lead to a decrease in use of these synthetic drugs, although this effect may not be notable.

Czechia

It was noted that climate change may lead to changes in distribution routes and production areas. It is important to monitor and report on changing supply routes (e.g., by the National Focal Point, police).

Netherlands

Climate change and environmental degradation may cause cultivation of natural drugs to shift to other locations or an increased focus on synthetic drugs. An increased attention on drug waste pollution may cause more focus on fairtrade/organic drugs. Climate stress may lead to increased drug use.

Portugal

The trends of climate crisis and environmental awareness were merged in the Portuguese exercise, given that one derives from the other. The interruption of response capacity, namely in a setting of catastrophe (fires, floods, etc.) is concerning as these events not only hinder access to responses, but also increase the population needs. In this way, reflecting on the catastrophe scenario, the Strategic Reserve, in Laboratory and Medicine Institute, is important as it has a reservoir of various medicines (to be used under a catastrophe), as well methadone. -The climate crisis and the extreme events associated with it, will highlight the socio-economic condition of some populations in greater vulnerability, contributing to situations of extreme poverty. This may lead to an increase in illicit drugs use as a response to social exclusion, as well as drug trafficking as an economic opportunity or livelihood. Increased focus is needed on communities in climate crisis zones, for example, the inhabitants of some vulnerable fishing communities.

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